

Recognize it

Deep colorful sunfish with turquoise cheek lines and orange/red mark on the ear flap.

Body	Mottled olive sides; orange belly; short rounded pectoral fin.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; stiff spiny dorsal joined to soft portion.
Confusion	Bluegill lacks the bright ear-flap margin and has a longer pointed pectoral fin.

Lake role

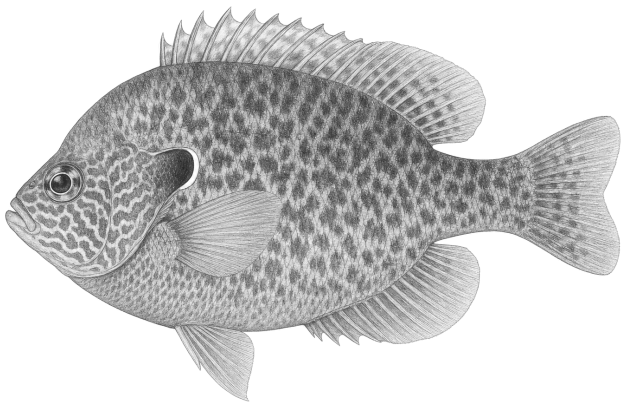
Where it belongs

Vegetated shallows, snails and insect-rich edges, firm spawning pockets.

Food and season

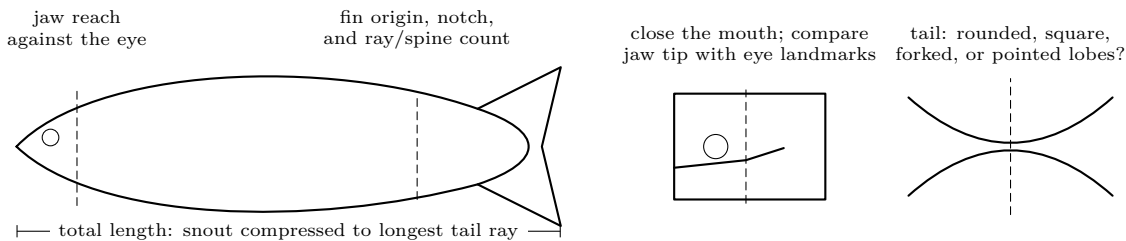
Invertebrates, especially snails and insects; shallow during warm spawning period.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



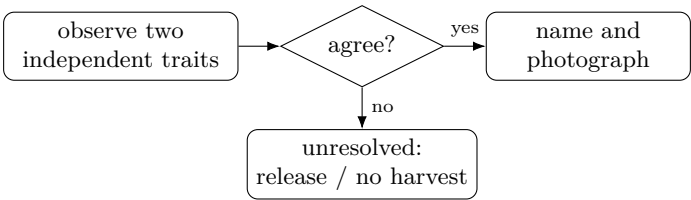
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Confirm a deep body, small mouth, and shorter rounded pectoral fin.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Inspect the ear flap for a distinct orange/red rear margin.
- 3. **Markings last.** Use wavy cheek lines as the second marking; brightness varies with season and light.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Pumpkinseed
Nearest alternative	Bluegill lacks the bright ear-flap margin and has a longer pointed pectoral fin.
Required gate	Pumpkinseed requires the colored flap margin plus short rounded pectoral or wavy cheek lines.
Independent check	Compare flap and pectoral on the same lateral view; never identify from overall color alone.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected weed pockets and gravel/sand openings, then the first green outside edge.
North	Test shallow vegetation and firm pockets in protected bays.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Separate mixed sunfish in the log; an unidentified *Lepomis* does not confirm either species.

Presentations

1. **Tiny float rig.** Present a worm segment or insect imitation near weed openings without burying it.
2. **Micro-jig.** Pitch a compact jig to visible pockets and pause near bottom.
3. **Stop rule.** Move when only very small fish respond; do not strip a nesting colony for a meal.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Fold the dorsal spines back, wet hands, and support the body rather than squeezing.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Use a modest number of thicker mid-size fish; release exceptional adults and active nest guards.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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